

The **TERI Research Group**: Teacher Education and Scholarship Through Knowledge Community

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Characteristics of the TERI Research Group

The collective construction of a knowledge community is paramount to the work of the TERI Research Group. Craig (1995; 2001) describes knowledge communities as, "safe, storytelling places where educators narrate the rawness of their experiences, negotiate meaning for such experiences, and authorize one's own and other's narrative interpretations of situations" (p. 668). Through our shared work with teacher candidates, research group members validate and consolidate our individual experiences and express our personal practical knowledge to one another (Huber & Whelan, 1995). In so doing, we can take intellectual risks in the development of our research projects and practices.

The TERI Research Group has provided doctoral students with an ongoing forum through which emerging educational researchers collaborate to establish a professional network that speaks across programs, research studies, and theoretical frameworks. Within our community, space is made to reveal tensions and share narratives so that we might reflectively revisit, reassess, and re-story our knowledge throughout the research process (Craig, 1995).

> "Collaboration is risky. Sharing research-in-progress, trying to stumble through your own thinking in the presence of others, requires even more risk. Yet from the first gathering of four people at a small table until now, when we frequently have to search for chairs so everyone can fit around a large table, we've built a space that encourages all of us to bring our diverse skills, expertise, knowledges, and stories to work on the challenges students, teachers, and researchers face. We are all getting smarter in the process" (doctoral candidate).

As such, our knowledge community follows a set of unwritten norms that consider our shared commitments and seek to honor and value work that is critical and collaborative. Those norms shift over time to accommodate the group's collective needs, including the social and emotional health and well-being of our members. Lateral and reciprocal learning takes place around research in our meetings; our knowledge community affords us the opportunity to develop and gain narrative authority as researchers without pressure to compete, impress, or perform what we are "supposed" to know. Thus, tension and discomfort--markers of learning and growth--aren't avoided, but reveled in, explored, and storied together. As a result, members of the community feel more connected to one another and their work, committed to critical and culturally relevant teacher education, and capable of individually making a difference.

Processes and Projects

> The TERI Research Group was created to provide a space for exploring individual and collective research questions embedded in teacher education programs at the University of Minnesota. Over time, the group has evolved into a knowledge community that learns together, creates new ideas together, and supports the scholarship of its members.
> -Dr. Mistilina Sato

Feedback on Individual Work: Members of the TERI Research Group have brought work from dissertations and other research projects, research assistant work, class projects, conference presentations, community work, and activism to the group for cross-disciplinary insight and critical, constructive feedback.

> "The TERI Research Group was instrumental to the framing of my doctoral thesis. My colleagues and advisors in the group provided the emotional and intellectual support that permitted me to frame my research around the, then, somewhat contested area of gender and sexual diversity in educator preparation programs. ….For me professionally, the TERI Research Group, shaped the teacher scholar that I became" (doctoral candidate).

> "As a spatial thinker, mapping the ideas offered by the group on the white board and later revisiting the photo of my map propelled me forward with my research questions and design. The encouraging tone of the feedback from peers, staff and faculty gave me the confidence I needed to begin to see myself as an educational researcher" (doctoral candidate).

Development of Dissertation Projects: Members of the TERI Research Group offer one another collaborative feedback and work on research design and questions, theoretical framing, methodology and methods, data collection and analysis.

Teacher Education Redesign Initiative (TERI) Projects: Initiated as part of the effort to redesign teacher education at the University, the research group provides a collaborative space to support the development and ongoing evaluation of common assessments for secondary licensure programs, such as the Teacher Identity Self Study, Professional Rotations, and Case Studies. Our knowledge community serves as a site for avenues of research connected to overarching TERI research and development framework; we represent many different disciplines and program areas and, as such, we serve as a regular meeting place for co-constructive, interdisciplinary work around teacher education at the University.

> "We [in C & I] get complacent sometimes. Or we think a problem is not as widespread as we thought and so we just move to another school . Here [in the TERI Research Group] we're digging into the work. [...T]his is a place where there's questioning about what is occurring" (C & I staff).

Program Evaluation: The TERI Research Group has provided input across license area programs for program evaluation tools and policies, including a co-teaching survey, focus group and interview questions for teacher candidates of color, and assessment of the role of C & I Initial Licensure Program admission essays and rubrics.

Dispositions Framework: The TERI Research Group elected to address a program-wide need to re-conceptualize and redesign the college's Dispositions Assessment for teacher candidates.

> "The synergy of ideas generated in the group is inspired. The commitment to high quality teacher education in the group is exceptional. And the rigor of the research and development work in which they jointly engage is demanding work. The future of teacher education will be in good hands with these scholar-practitioners of teacher education" (Dr. Sato).

Commitments

Critical and culturally relevant teacher preparation and ongoing growth and development of these approaches in our departments and programs.

Advocacy in support of students in schools and work toward a more socially just system of public education.

Honoring each individual's expertise and insights and the perspectives they bring to the community.

The cultivation of collegiality and a desire to learn from and with one another.

Deep, careful, engaged listening of one another's stories, struggles, ideas, theories, and questions.

> "I won't go to an institution as a researcher, if they won't allow this kind of a collaborative research group process" (doctoral student).

Community History

Fall 2011 - Dr. Mistilina Sato brings together three doctoral students engaged in research in teacher education to meet weekly to discuss research projects.

Dr. Sato invites all doctoral students taking CI 8151 to attend weekly research group meetings.

Spring 2012 - TERI research group grows to nine members.

Fall 2012 - Graduate assistantship established to facilitate research group, run meetings, keep agenda, notes, etc.

Spring 2013 - Research Group grows to 15 members.

Current (2014) membership sits at approximately 20.

Research group includes M.Ed. and Ph.D. students, teacher education staff and faculty.

Members of the TERI Research Group have presented at AACTE and AERA, the CEHD Research Day, and the C & I Research Day for the past three years.

The Research Group has made presentations to the C & I Licensed School Professionals committee multiple times in the past three years and has supported the dissertation research of seven doctoral students, focused on teacher education inquiries.

Jehanne Beaton serves as the TERI Research group coordinator. She can be contacted at beat0012@umn.edu. Shannon McManimon (mcman093@edu.umn), Miranda Schornack, and Erin Stutelberg (stute023@umn.edu) all are members of the TERI research group and are happy to provide further information about the research group.

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